11

VOLUNTEER-LED SPORT (AND COACH) DEVELOPMENT

A Case Study of Pickleball in Scotland

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Introduction

This chapter explores the development of a new sport and the work towards establishing a National Governing Body (NGB), by case studying the sport of Pickleball in Scotland. Two of the authors of this chapter are actively involved in Pickleball and therefore draw on their experiences of the sport in Scotland to outline the lived experiences of developing a system for an emerging sport. This section of the chapter introduces the fundamentals of sport development and some of the specifics of the sport of Pickleball and its growing popularity. This is followed by a discussion of the development of a sport organisation and finally the role of people in developing a sport, including establishing leadership and governance for the sport and key aspects of sport development and the role of coaching.

The fundamentals of sport development are generally accepted as being related to the provision of opportunities for people to participate in a certain sport, group of sports or physical activity (Shilbury et al, 2008). Lyle (2012: 498) described sport development as "a layered framework of facilitated sport-related activity", noting in particular that different participant groups have different needs when it comes to how the sport is coached. The nature of provision might vary but there are common features including the need for appropriate and safe space for participation, specific types of equipment or kit in some cases, and knowledgeable leaders to introduce the sport and help people develop their skills, many of whom work in a voluntary capacity. Critical to the development of any sport is the role of NGBs (also known as National Sport Organisations – NSOs).

Pickleball

Pickleball was invented by an American family some 50 years ago and is a central net game, played with paddles and an airflow ball. Pickleball has been a popular

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sport in the USA for many years, but has only reached Europe and other parts of the world in the past decade. Participation rates are difficult to measure as it remains a relatively unknown sport, but some estimates put the number of regular players in the USA at 5 million, with a further 2 million elsewhere in the world. Pickleball has been played in Scotland for over ten years, and the endeavours of a small group of committed volunteers led to the establishment of an embryonic organisation to lead the sport in 2018. Pickleball Scotland is a wholly voluntary organisation with the sole purpose of promoting and supporting the development of the sport in Scotland and seeking official status as the NGB for Pickleball in Scotland. There are a range of activities focused on growing participation, establishing routes for coaching and organising the sport with good governance and integrity, which are discussed in this chapter.

BOX 11.1

THE FUNDAMENTALS OF PICKLEBALL

Pickleball is a central net game played with paddles (akin to oversize table tennis bats – see Figure 11.1) and an airflow ball (see Figure 11.2) on a small court with a net height of 1 metre. Some say the sport *looks like* a game of mini-tennis but there are important differences. The use of non-strung rackets and a hard ball means that the flight pattern of the ball is very true – players do not need to compensate for playing on a small court by hitting more gently than they would like to, because the ball will go exactly where

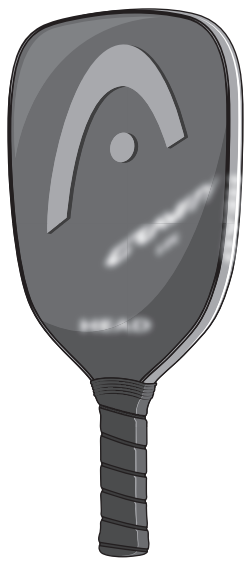

FIGURE 11.1 Pickleball paddle.

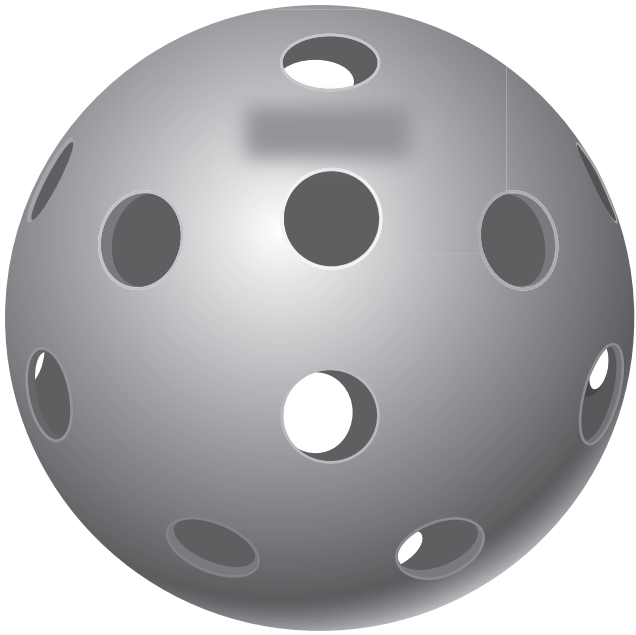

FIGURE 11.2 Pickleball ball.

and how you want it to go (strung rackets have a lot more rebound, so the balls are less easy to control).

The rules too are an important feature that make this activity unique and accessible. One rule is the 'no-volley zone' – this is the area from the net to a line just behind the badminton service line, 7 feet back from the net (see Figure 11.3), inside which the players are not allowed to play a volley-shot. This

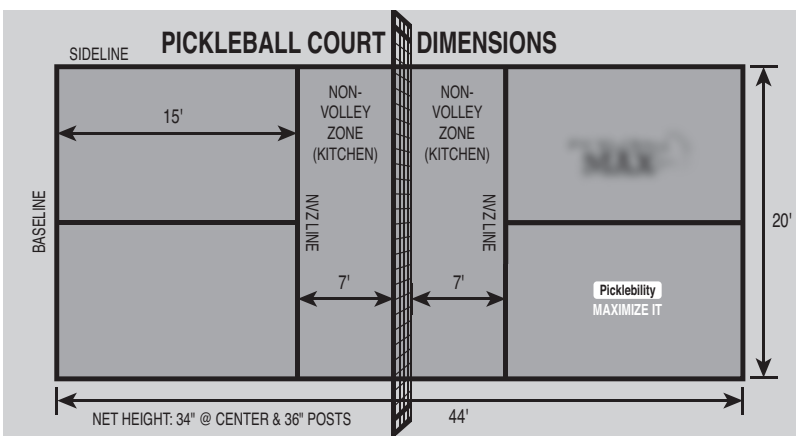

FIGURE 11.3 Pickleball court.

prevents players from being too domineering at the net, and the rule helps to take overly aggressive shots out of the game. The second unique rule is the 'double-bounce' rule. The server must serve underarm from the back of the court and the receiver must let the serve bounce once before playing the return shot (just like tennis); but … the server must also let this service return shot bounce once before playing their next shot. This prevents the server from playing a serve and volley game and supports rallies to get underway. The nature and rules of the sport mean that there is no need to make adaptations to equipment or playing space, unlike sports such as tennis and badminton.

A key feature of Pickleball is its accessibility and inclusiveness, as discussed in both Boxes 11.1 and 11.2. Inclusion is an important consideration within sport development as understanding different participant groups is crucial for developing a sport and ensuring provision, including facilities and coaching, are appropriate. This can be particularly valuable when considering social groups that are less likely to be engaged in sport, such as older adults. As Jenkin et al (2021) discussed, lower intensity sports can be appealing to older adults and understanding why older adults have chosen to (re-)engage with sport can enable those leading sport to consider ways to develop and deliver sport which is suitable for that demographic.

BOX 11.2

PICKLEBALL AS AN INCLUSIVE SPORT

The popularity of Pickleball is closely linked to its accessibility: it is relatively easy for new players, young and old, to pick up the basics of the sport and quickly become competitive and successful at the sport. The sport is popular amongst older people as it provides an opportunity to be physically active in a directly competitive sport. One enclave of Pickleball popularity is an area known as The Villages in Florida, USA, which is a community of over-50s.

This inclusivity extends to events and competitions. The competition structure enables players to compete against others of similar age and ability – attend any of the larger tournaments and you will see novices, intermediates and experts of all ages competing with others in the same age and ability categories. This competition structure, along with the organic nature of the growth of the sport, makes it a very sociable, friendly and supportive environment in which to enjoy competing at all levels.

Developing an Emerging Sport

As noted in the introduction to this chapter, there are common fundamental components of sport development, and these are important at any stage in a sport's development but particularly as a sport becomes established both in terms of participation numbers and in terms of becoming more formalised in its nature, including the establishment of an NGB. Critical in this process is the role of people with specific skills and a commitment to the sport that means that they are willing to contribute to the development of the sport as volunteers.

Professionalisation and Formalisation

Kikulis et al (1992) identified archetypes of professionalised organisations, specifically the 'kitchen table', which is an organisation with a lack of professionalisation and bureaucracy, the 'boardroom' where there is a bureaucracy and a formal structure and the 'executive office', where the organisation has both bureaucracy and a fully formalised and professionalised set of roles. As Dowling et al (2014) note, this archetype is well utilised in the sport management literature. The formalisation of an organisation's work refers to the standardisation of specific roles and structures within the organisation (Hoye et al, 2015; Nichols et al, 2015) and can be used to increase efficiency and effectiveness of the organisation (Pedras et al, 2020). The extent of professionalisation can in turn impact on formalisation (Dowling et al, 2014). As Pickleball Scotland has developed as an organisation, so there has been a focus on having the staff[1] conducting specific work to contribute to the development of the sport and of the organisation, reflecting the notion of formalisation, drawing on the knowledge and skillsets that the founding members of the organisation possess. This is detailed further later in this chapter.

The increasing professionalisation and formalisation of NGBs in Scotland and the wider UK setting has meant that contemporary research about NGBs tends to focus on their now business-like conduct and the policy decisions and mechanisms that have brought about these conditions (Houlihan and Green, 2009; Tacon and Walters, 2016). This extends to discussions of professionalisation of specific roles in sport, though Dowling et al (2014) noted that research about occupational professionalisation in sport is not as advanced as research relating to organisational professionalisation, and coaching as a profession is often omitted within management-related research. When considering the governance, management and professionalisation of sport in Scotland specifically, there is a dearth of academic literature, in spite of the trajectory of Scottish sport being similar to that in other parts of the UK.

Governance

Governance is an increasingly significant aspect of research related to sports organisations, but there is no fixed definition of what is meant by the term

(Thompson et al, 2022). A systematic review of research by Thompson et al (2022) found that the principles of transparency, accountability and democracy are key features of the discussion of governance in the literature and that governance is multi-level and multi-dimensional and that it is necessary to understand the context of the organisation. In the UK, governance standards for organisations are set out by the sports councils. These standards are designed to ensure that there is good organisational governance amongst organisations that are recognised by the councils and particularly those that are in receipt of public funding as adopting formal practices can be a condition of receiving funding (Nichols et al, 2015). However, meeting these standards can require specific human resources both in terms of time and knowledge in order to develop structures and recruit expertise to an organisation. Walters and Tacon (2018) discuss the adoption of the governance standards as a way for sport organisations to achieve legitimacy, but also a valuable tool in shaping the organisation's work and ensuring accountability.

In Scotland, sportscotland, the national sports council, has good governance as a condition of funding for NGBs, and their framework to guide this aligns with similar standards elsewhere in the UK (sportscotland, 2021). Some aspects of the governance standards that sportscotland set out transcend sport as they are informed by the recommendations of the Nolan Committee, which outlines standards for publicly funded organisations in Scotland, and the framework focuses on key aspects such as accountability through planning and reporting, clearly defined roles and responsibilities within the organisations, and strong leadership (sportscotland, 2021). In order to achieve governance standards, a range of skills are needed to lead a sport: sportscotland (2021) and Nichols et al (2015) noted the importance of matching skills to volunteer and board roles in sport organisations. As will be discussed further later in this chapter, the staff involved in Pickleball Scotland have varied employment and academic backgrounds that collectively lend themselves well to successfully developing and leading the sport.

Achieving Recognition as a Sport

As new sports emerge, become codified and develop national and international structures, there can be risks to their autonomy as decisions are taken as to whether they are distinct sports, or a subsidiary or adapted form of another sport (Box 11.3). As Washington and Patterson (2011) discuss, there can be conflict amongst stakeholders with an interest in a sport and how it is governed, and by whom. This is a challenge that Pickleball Scotland had faced (as discussed in Box 11.4) and has also been an issue in the recent past for the sport of Parkour. In the case of Parkour, the Federation Internationale de Gymnastique (FIG) has sought to bring under its banner, in part so that it can be included as an Olympic discipline, something that has been strongly resisted by Parkour athletes and organisations around the world (Bull, 2018).

BOX 11.3

GAINING RECOGNITION FOR THE SPORT

A key motivator for the founding members of Pickleball Scotland in establishing the NGB and seeking recognition of the sport from the sports councils was to protect the integrity of the sport. The first step in this process was meeting with sportscotland to discuss the process of becoming recognised as the NGB. The founders were informed that the UK sports councils (UK Sport and the home nation sports councils) would first need to be convinced that Pickleball was in fact a distinctive sport and not a subsidiary of one of the established racket sports. Pickleball was already gaining attention and in particular was being considered an alternative to tennis, so there was a concern that Tennis Scotland might be considered a better option for governing the sport. Beyond Scotland, there could be implications for Pickleball organisations and the governance of the sport in the other UK home nations (England, Northern Ireland and Wales) and internationally if a decision was taken that Pickleball was not a sport in its own right.

Fortunately, the CEOs of both Tennis Scotland and Badminton Scotland confirmed that Pickleball should not fall under either NGBs' remits. Furthermore, at this stage, the Pickleball Scotland team moved to work with their counterparts in England to draft a statement of uniqueness and began working through a set of requirements from sportscotland for their recognition, which included building membership within Scotland.

Once again, the proactivity of the Pickleball Scotland team of volunteers has been critical to ensuring the sport is protected as a sport in its own right and is being governed with integrity. There is a clear aim to establish and maintain the organisation and to network with key organisations that can support their endeavours.

In the case of Pickleball, the professionalisation and formalisation of the sport and the work towards establishing an NGB is in its early stages so it is not easy to compare this case with other NGBs and their practices. However, we can explore the nature of the voluntary work being done by staff involved with developing the sport and Pickleball Scotland. It should be noted that the development of the sport and the organisation is not linear: the staff and those with whom they are networked in Scottish sport have experienced tensions and challenges, and it has been necessary to pilot ideas and seek feedback in order to move the development forward. The extensive work of gaining recognition for a new sport and establishing a new NGB, along with the work to develop a system for the sport, cannot be achieved without the input of well-positioned, skilled and knowledgeable individuals. The next section of this chapter will discuss the role of people in developing sport.

The Role of People in Developing a Sport

Institutional Work

Institutional work can be described as the endeavours of individuals or groups to construct, maintain and/or disrupt institutions, be they specific organisations or values and norms that exist within a social space (Lawrence and Suddaby, 2006). Institutional work has been highlighted by scholars such as Dowling and Smith (2016) for its potential for understanding the role of individuals and groups in shaping sport-related institutional settings. Crucially, as Lawrence and Suddaby (2006: 219) noted, institutional work is done by "culturally competent actors with strong practical skills and sensibility who creatively navigate within their organizational fields"; those *doing* the institutional work need to have appropriate knowledge, skills and networks. The work conducted can vary in nature from minor to major (Dowling and Smith 2016): seemingly small, banal activities, such as the writing-up of documents, can be overlooked but are important aspects of institutional work and the shaping of institutions.

A critical aspect of discussions of institutional work is that people engaging in institutional work are active in that process: they are deliberately seeking to influence (through establishment, maintenance and/or disruption) institutions (Lawrence et al, 2011). Being successful in this work requires people to have knowledge of the context and how the current situation has developed, but also to be able to look to the future (Lawrence et al, 2011). The knowledge and skills of the Pickleball Scotland staff and their experiences as participants in the sport make them well equipped and well positioned to carry out the necessary institutional work to establish the NGB and develop the sport in Scotland.

Volunteers

The role of volunteers in sports clubs has been widely discussed in academic literature (for example, Donnelly and Harvey, 2012; Kay and Bradbury, 2009; Taylor et al, 2012) and the significance of volunteering within sport is recognised by sports councils, which also promote volunteering opportunities. Taylor et al (2012: 201) stated, "Volunteers are central to the sport policy context in the United Kingdom" and noted that as well as volunteers being significant in delivery of sport, they are also part of the governance of sport within NGBs. In Scotland, sportscotland promotes volunteering within sport, outlining the benefits of volunteering in terms of developing an individual's skills and knowledge (sportscotland, 2022a). According to the 2019 Scottish Household Survey, approximately 26% of the population in Scotland are engaged in voluntary work (Scottish Government, 2020).

As Nichols et al (2015) note, drawing on the work of Cnann et al (1996), there is a difference between roles with formal and informal volunteering in club settings, with the latter tending to be people who hold specific roles in the club's governance structure or more technical roles such as coaches. Volunteers

need to have appropriate skills and qualities and be deployed appropriately (Nichols et al, 2015), thus the work needed to be undertaken in the development of a sport, though reliant on volunteers, needs to have appropriate people engaging in this work. In Scotland, as part of its promotion of volunteering, sportscotland provides role descriptions and case studies of volunteer roles in sport to support people's understanding of the skills that volunteers might need (sportscotland, 2022b).

BOX 11.4

WORK OF PICKLEBALL SCOTLAND 'STAFF'

Three of the founding members of the fledgling Pickleball Scotland NGB came to the table with more than their enthusiasm for the sport. One founding member was a retired accountant who was the Chair of the Finance Committee for Badminton Scotland. The second was the Major Events Operations Manager for Badminton Scotland, with a background in physical education. And the third was the person who brought Pickleball across from the USA, a businessperson with an ability to establish positive networking opportunities with a variety of people who could help the establishment and growth of the organisation – it was she who became and remains the first Chair of Pickleball Scotland.

The networks of the Pickleball Scotland staff were essential: they were able to draw advice from a range of other sports organisations including current and former leaders of other NGBs in Scotland to seek advice and buy-in for the work to become recognised as a stand-alone sport and NGB. The staff have also made use of local connections and had direct discussions with facility owners, including tennis clubs, to make use of those facilities to help build the participant base.

Further work is needed in terms of strategic networking with different stakeholders in the sport industry in Scotland and developing sustainable clubs that can grow their membership and thus help the sport to grow further. There is a dedicated member of the committee to conduct this work who has a strong business background but less knowledge in relation to sport development, though this has not been an issue in developing connections thus far. It is potentially the case that the different perspective she has in *not* coming from a sport-related background is a benefit to the organisation.

Coaching

As noted in the introduction of this chapter, having people with suitable knowledge is vital for the development of sport so that new players can be appropriately and safely introduced to the sport, and those already involved in the sport can develop

their skills. As Lyle (2012) highlighted, there are different needs in relation to coaching or leadership depending on the characteristics of the participant group(s).

As a sport becomes formalised and organisations leading the sport look to grow participation levels and build infrastructure for the sport to flourish, developing coaches is often part of that process. For example, as Parkour has become more established, so it has faced these questions of how to develop a coaching system as part of a process of legitimisation of the sport (Sterchele and Ferrero Camoletto, 2017). Developing a coaching system is challenging in Parkour due to the nature of the sport being organic and the importance of, as Sterchele and Ferrero Camoletto (2017: 92) note, "experiential learning" and "peer learning", thus having a formal coach education system in place has been resisted by some groups involved in the sport. Although Pickleball is a more 'traditional' sport than Parkour, the growth in its popularity in Scotland (and indeed elsewhere in the world) has been somewhat organic so there is the potential for existing participants to resist the input of an NGB and a formal coach development system. Traditionally, the national and international federations for a sport are the caretakers of the sport's rules and structures, including competition, and, at a national level, the NGB leads key aspects of the sport's development, such as developing a coaching system. The institutional work of people involved in Pickleball and the NGB becomes critical in this case as they make use of their knowledge of the development of the sport to date, the context in which the NGB is operating and their view of the potential development of the sport, including the development of coaching, as discussed in Box 11.5.

BOX 11.5

PICKLEBALL SCOTLAND AND COACHING

Developing coaches and having a committee member responsible for coaching was a priority for Pickleball Scotland. The first need was to train people in how to introduce the game to people who had never played. The Ambassadors' training package was evolved enabling those who were trained as Ambassadors to grow the game in Scotland. This was also an opportunity to lay the foundations of Pickleball Scotland's approach to developing the game. The five principles evolved for Ambassadors to use were: provide a brief history of the game, be safe, introduce the game bit by bit, ensure games are fun, encourage people to register as players on Pickleball Scotland's website (https://www.pickleballscotland.org) (Figure 11.4).

While it is important to consider the existing participant base when developing a system for the sport, there also needs to be consideration of future players of all ages and experiences. Therefore, Pickleball Scotland took a two-pronged approach: one set of work for engaging adults and another for working with young people.

FIGURE 11.4 Ambassadors in training.

In terms of working with adults, the NGB staff have now written a programme that is of a similar philosophy to the UKCC programme, that is, educating coaches to be reflective practitioners and which equips them with the tools to be adaptive pedagogues. They could have reverted to a more traditional approach to coaching which focuses much more on content-knowledge and a structured skills-based approach. However, in order to make Pickleball Scotland have its own brand and making use of the coaching expertise of the volunteers, the reflective practitioner approach is the one they followed. A key branding aspect here is that after attending the workshop, participants have to complete three reflective journals on three different coaching sessions to then qualify as a club coach. There are also plans to create a performance coach award in the future.

In terms of working with younger people, the NGB has explored how to enable new and younger players to engage with the sport, so they have developed resource for secondary schools that respect current ideas of facilitative teaching approaches. A next step will be to draw the various resources together as they could be used by upper secondary schools and further education establishments to help teach sports leadership, introductory sports coaching and event management. A key challenge for moving this work forwards is money!

There is also a resource to support club and competition organisers, which is freely available on the Pickleball Scotland website.

Getting to this point has been an interesting journey. The key personnel involved with writing the resources, and training courses are highly experienced in their professional fields. However, each of these fields is different,

and so it follows that each person's perspective of what these resources and courses should look like differs too. We also came with our own experiences of 'being' coached and taught, and this too had an impact on our individual vision for courses – we all had memories of great, and not so great, courses that we had attended over the years and these, along with our professional and academic understanding of coaching and teaching, influenced our perspectives. The key thing to note is that we all had a shared philosophy of collegiate and reflective practice. This enabled us to work collaboratively to write and test our courses, and after reflection (self-reflection, group reflection and feedback from course attendees), we were able to amend and re-test our courses. This cycle of testing, reflecting and amending will be continuous and will help us to evolve more naturally, and it will also help prevent us from becoming too fixed in our way of thinking and working. This cycle of reflection and re-action is what we ask of our coaching course attendees. Of course, one of the challenges that we need to be cognisant of is how our courses are perceived and valued by others. We are not aligned to a national coaching programme, nor are we offering courses that are accredited by an examining body or even the two Pickleball international federations. So, the question of gaining a 'qualification' through Pickleball Scotland courses is, at the moment at least, in the eye of the beholder! This is potentially another book chapter in its own right – how are sports courses valued and given credence? Who, ultimately, has the authority to decide if a course 'qualifies' an attendee to become a coach?

Concluding Remarks

This chapter has drawn on the experiences of people working in the sport of Pickleball in Scotland to illuminate the challenges and opportunities of developing and new system for sport. With the sport being in the process of becoming formalised in its structures in Scotland and with a growing profile and participant base, volunteers who are leading the sport and beginning the process of establishing a system for developing the sport and considering the role of coach development within this system.

The Pickleball Scotland management board have demonstrated a combined top-down and bottom-up approach to develop this growing sport in Scotland. The responsibilities that the founding members have assumed, and how they have used both their own sets of skills and knowledge and made use of networks in sport in Scotland to create a new organisation that is seeking confirmation as the sport's NGB, show a careful top-down approach to ensure the integrity of the sport and its governing body. They have also ensured that the needs of current and potential players are considered in their planning, and indeed, they are players themselves so they have strong connections to the grassroots of the sport in Scotland.

Moving forward, the development of the sport will rely upon an ongoing increase in the number of regular players and competitors and establishing a secure infrastructure for people to play regularly, including access to appropriate facilities and a calendar of competitions and events to engage those who want to develop their skills and compete in the sport that they enjoy. The further development of a system for developing coaches will aid in growing the sport. For now, the NGB staff continue their institutional work to establish the sport and the organisation governing the sport in Scotland, whilst being mindful of the challenges they face: the primary challenge being having a sustainable income to further the development of the sport.

Note

1 Within this chapter when we refer to 'staff' within Pickleball Scotland, these are not paid individuals but altruistically motivated individuals committing their own time to the sport and to the organisation.

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